

GENERAL FACTS ABOUT THE WORLD OF OUR ELECTION

THE BROADER EUROPEAN SITUATION (somewhat simplified for our simulation):

1. **King Charles VIII of France** is the most powerful king in Europe, young, and warlike. He has (tenuous) claims to the thrones of Naples and Milan, and recently invaded Burgundy.
2. **Anne Duchess of Brittany** rules an independent territory at the northwest edge of France, which France is eager to seize. She married Emperor Maximilian by proxy a year ago, threatening to give Brittany to the Empire, but Charles kidnapped her and bribed the now-dead Pope Innocent to annul the marriage with Maximilian so he could marry Anne himself. She and Charles have had one stillborn child, and some say God has cursed their union.
3. **The two halves of Spain** (which are usually enemies) are merging. King Ferdinand of Aragon (the east half) married Queen Isabella of Castile (west half), though she is more powerful than her husband. Their son John and eldest daughter Isabella died, and their 2nd daughter Joanna—now their heir—is the widow of Philip of Burgundy, son of Emperor Maximilian, so Joana's young son Prince Carlos is in line to inherit Spain and the Empire.
4. **Emperor Maximilian Hapsburg** has not yet had his third coronation. He was crowned King of Germany at Aachen, but still needs to be crowned King of Italy in Milan with the ancient *Iron Crown of Lombardy* (made from a nail used at the Crucifixion), and then Emperor in Rome by the new pope. Maximilian is a widower and now unmarried, unless you count his interrupted marriage with Anne of Brittany. His heir is his grandson Carlos, now in Spain. Emperors must be *elected* to rule, so if Maximilian wants his grandson to inherit, he must win over the seven Prince Electors, powerful nobles who vote for the Emperor.
5. **Burgundy** is a rich duchy (actually it's a complicated federation of things but duchy works as a simplification) lying between France and the Holy Roman Empire. Its last independent sovereign Duchess Mary was Emperor Maximilian's first wife. After her death the Duchy passed to her son Philip (now dead), then to her grandson Charles Hapsburg, the same boy prince who is in line to inherit both Spain and the Empire. Emperor Maximilian is eager to control Burgundy during his grandson's minority, but the warlike Charles of France invaded and seized the western half, while Maximilian hold the east. Border violence is constant.
6. **The Swiss Republic** is part of the Empire, impregnable, and supplies TONS of mercenaries.
7. **Savoy** is part of the Empire, south of Switzerland between France (Provence) & Italy (Milan). It has been dominated by France through marriages (King Charles's mother was from Savoy), but the current duke **Prince-Elector Carlo Amadeo** is a toddler in the care of his mother Blanche of Montferrat, who's half Sforza (Milan) half Palaeologus (Byzantium).
8. **The Kingdom of Hungary** is weak from dynastic trouble and Ottoman attack. King Matthias Corvinus was strong and popular, aided by his brilliant **Queen Beatrice** (daughter of King Ferrante of Naples), and his legendary fighting force the *Black Army*. He died without an heir, and in the ensuing civil war Emperor Maximilian almost seized the throne, but the Hungarian people loved Queen Beatrice they let her pick any husband she wanted and make him king so she could stay queen. The new **King Vladislaus** is the eldest son of King Casimir of Poland, but earlier became a vassal of Maximilian who tried to make him King of Bohemia. Vladislaus's marriage to Beatrice is bigamous, and his first wife Barbara of Brandenburg is imprisoned, a situation which can only be solved by the death of one wife, or by a papal annulment. Vladislaus is so bellicose that his father Casimir has disowned him, leaving Poland to a younger son, for fear that Vladislaus would mire the kingdom in war.

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9. Old **King João II of Portugal** “the Perfect Prince” has brought Portugal great prosperity, largely by banishing its more obstreperous nobility. His heir Crown Prince Afonso died in a strange accident last year—he was married to Princess Isabella, eldest daughter of Ferdinand & Isabella, and if he had lived he might have united both Portugal with its long-time enemies Aragon & Castile. King Joao’s bookish queen Leonor is very influential.
10. **King Henry VII of England** grew up in Brittany, and took England by force from Richard III, ending the Wars of the Roses. His claim to the throne is weak, and there are several in with rival claims (notably *Perkin Warbek*, *Countess Margaret Pole* and strange astronomer *Baron Henry Clifford*) but Henry has a good claim to the throne of France. He has two sons.
11. Unmarried **King James of Scotland**, England’s northern neighbor, is an ally of France. Scotland attacked England often during England’s recent civil wars, but is quiet now.
12. The vast **Kingdom of Naples** (southern Italy) was French-held until 50 years ago (1442) when *King Alfonso of Aragon* conquered it, aiming to make a new empire to rival the German emperors. He had no legitimate son, so Aragon went to his brother, while he left Naples to his illegitimate son *King Ferrante*, who is a bit of a tyrant. With a weak claim to power and the hatred of his people, Ferrante was nearly overthrown under Pope Innocent in the *War of the Conspiracy of the Barons*, in which the pope, the della Rovere, and Colonna tried to annex Naples to the Papal States, but Ferrante was defended by the Orsini & Medici. The French claim to Naples has passed to the ambitious *King Charles of France*, who is likely to invade to seize this largest, richest part of Italy. Ferrante’s son *Crown Prince Alfonso* married the brilliant *Princess Ippolita Maria Sforza* of Milan, but she died, and he married his mistress *Trogia Gazzela*. Naples contains many counties and duchies, including **Amalfi** ruled by the *Piccolomini*, and **Salerno & Caiazzo** ruled by the *Sanseverino*. The independent *della Rovere*-ruled duchy of **Sora** stands between Naples & Rome.
13. The **Ottoman Empire** recently conquered Greece & Constantinople, and briefly invaded Italy. The new Sultan Bayezid II is threatened by his half-brother **Sultan Cem** (pronounced “Jem”) who also claims the throne, but is currently in Rome, a prisoner of the Pope. Bayezid just made peace with **Sultan Qa’it Bay** of Egypt, ending a long war. What will he do next?
14. A “**New World**” has just been discovered across the Atlantic Ocean, and Spain and Portugal are fighting over it. The new pope will be called upon to decide who gets it.
15. There are many **monastic orders**; the Benedictines are old & respected, but currently the Franciscans and Dominicans are competing fiercely political influence. France supports Franciscans & Spain supports Dominicans. Dominicans are scholars and run the Inquisition.
16. The last time a Frenchman was pope, France moved the papacy to Avignon and sparked a century of war. Every Italian has vowed: “No French Popes!” (Unless the price is right...)

FACTS ABOUT CENTRAL/NORTHERN ITALY: a chaos of independent city-states that all hate each other. The strongest are Milan, Venice, Florence, and Rome—all of which have small empires dominating neighboring cities—followed by Ferrara, Genoa, Bologna, Urbino, & Siena. Italy is divided in half by mountains, the Apennines, so cities by mountain passes are important.

17. **Milan** rules the region of **Lombardy** (northeast Italy), controls trade across the Alps, and is part of the Empire. It is ruled by the warlike Visconti-Sforza. Its current duke Ludovico recently deposed his weak nephew Gian Galeazzo (whom he holds prisoner). Charles of France has a claim to Milan, since the Sforza have only *illegitimate* Visconti blood.

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18. **Venice** is impregnable and aloof, tied more to recently-fallen Byzantium than to Rome. It has a vast navy, an empire of ports scattered over the Mediterranean, and vast trade networks, and its own Inquisition, independent from Rome's. Venice rules the northeast region of Italy (the Veneto) whose main city, Padua, contains the University of Padua, a haven for heresy.
19. **Ferrara** is the buffer between Venetian territory and the pope. Many think that if Ferrara falls and Venice & the pope fight, all Italy will destabilize and the Ottomans will invade, so attacking Ferrara endangers all Christendom. It is ruled by the House d'Este, the most respected noble house in Italy. Young Duke Alfonso is seeking a bride. His brother Ippolito is a Cardinal, and their mother is the sister of Queen Beatrice of Hungary.
20. **Genoa**, near Milan, was a republic ruled by its noble council and elected doge, usually someone from the rival & treacherous *Campofregoso* or *Adorno* families. Its empire rivaled Venice's, but recently it has been dominated by France, or (currently) Milan. Genoa is home to the *Gentili* & *Cybo* families and the *della Rovere* & *Riario* families recently returned there from exile. The last two popes were both Genoese, so it has grown in their days of power.
21. **Florence** is a pit of depravity, and a center of wealth, art, and scholarship. It wiped out its nobility, and is ruled by merchant scum. For decades it has been corruptly ruled by the Medici. Lorenzo de Medici is a great statesman, and some say a Philosopher Prince. 14 years ago the Medici were nearly wiped out in the Pazzi Conspiracy, led by the *della Rovere*, and the mercenary Duke Federico da Montefeltro of Urbino. A charismatic preacher named Savonarola has been gaining power in the city recently.
22. **Siena, Pisa, and Volterra** are towns in Tuscany, largely under Florentine domination.
 - a) **Siena** is a republic, the seat of the Franciscan bank, and independent so long as it never resists Florence's supremacy in Tuscany. Its most powerful family is the *Piccolomini*.
 - b) **Pisa** is Tuscany's port, and once had a sea empire, but has been crushed & conquered by its foe Florence. Its university is where rich families send sons training for the Church.
 - c) **Volterra** is a small town recently sacked by Florence in a dispute over an alum mine; both Lorenzo de Medici and Federico da Montefeltro of Urbino were partly to blame.
23. **The Papal States**—containing two regions, smaller Lazio on the west side of the mountains and larger Romagna on the east—are filled with semi-independent city states that often change hands as popes appoint new governors. The strongest are **Urbino, Mantua, Rimini, & Bologna**, followed by **Forlì, Viterbo, & Mirandola**. Currently, **Urbino** is controlled by the warlike but cultured Duke *Guidobaldo da Montefeltro* (Ghibelline) & his wife *Elizabetta Gonzaga*, whose brother *Francesco Gonzaga* is Marquess of **Mantua**. **Bologna** (Guelph) is a republic ruled by "First Citizen" *Giovanni Bentivoglio* & his wife *Ginerva Sforza*. The port of **Rimini** is ruled by the infamous *Malatesta* mercenaries. **Forlì** is ruled by *Lady Caterina Sforza Riario* (widow of *Girolamo Riario*, a nephew of *Pope Sixtus*). **Mirandola** is a weak city ruled by *Count Anton Maria Pico della Mirandola*, elder brother of the genius humanist Pico who is currently living in Florence under house arrest since being excommunicated for heresy for attempting to unite all world religions into one. Down in Lazio, Rome's neighbor **Viterbo** belongs to the *Farnese* family, old Roman nobles but weak and deep in debt.
24. **Rome itself** is ruled by the pope, but has a proud republican tradition. The Roman Mob (i.e. rioting) & the city's nobles (*Orsini, Colonna, Farnese*) can make any pope's reign miserable.
25. **Guelphs & Ghibellines** are rival Italian factions. Guelphs (led by the *Orsini*) believe the pope is Italy's rightful ruler, while Ghibellines (led by the *Colonna*) say it is the Emperor.